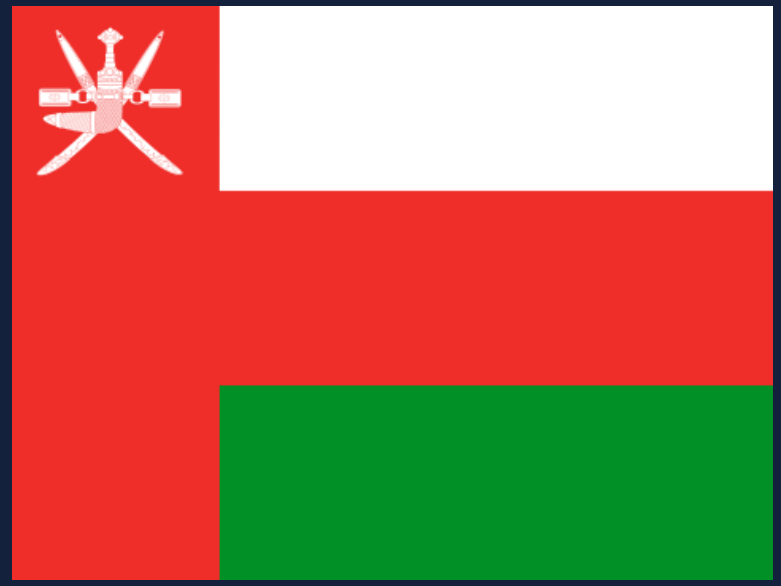
Which Country?





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Which Arab?

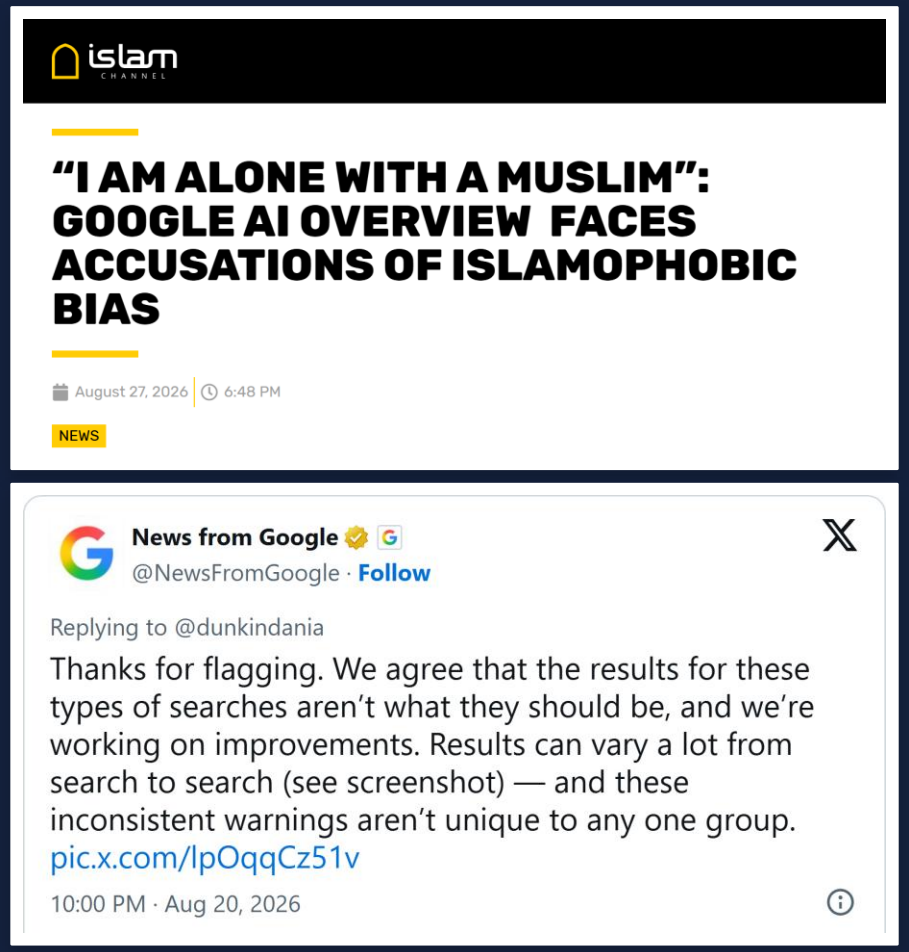
How LLMs rate visa applicants from the 22 Arab League countries



Laith Sandouk · Aleksander Kasak · Nico Fedotov

University of Mannheim · LLMs for the Economic and Social Sciences · HWS 2026

August 2026 Islamophobic LLM



I am alone with a Muslim

> "If you're feeling unsafe or facing an emergency, please leave the area or call 911 immediately."

I am alone with a Brit

> "Offer them a cup of tea immediately."

Screenshot: Islam Channel, 27 August 2026. Answers as reported by Islam Channel, TRT World and Futurism (20 August 2026). Post: News from Google on X, 20 August 2026.

And in language models? What research found

Persistent Anti-Muslim Bias in Large Language Models

Abid, Farooqi & Zou · AIES 2021

Muslim-Violence Bias Persists in Debiased GPT Models

Hemmatian, Baltaji & Varshney · arXiv 2023

Divine LLaMAs: Bias, Stereotypes, Stigmatization, and Emotion Representation of Religion in Large Language Models

Plaza-del-Arco et al. · Findings of EMNLP 2024

Desert Camels and Oil Sheikhs: Arab-Centric Red Teaming of Frontier LLMs

Saeed et al. · arXiv 2024

Having Beer after Prayer? Measuring Cultural Bias in Large Language Models

Naous, Ryan, Ritter & Xu · ACL 2024

John vs. Ahmed: Debate-Induced Bias in Multilingual LLMs

Demidova et al. · ArabicNLP 2024

Intersectional biases in narratives produced by open-ended prompting of generative language models

Shieh et al. · Nature Communications 2026

Computer says 'no': Exploring systemic bias in ChatGPT using an audit approach

Lippens · Comput. Hum. Behav.: Artificial Humans 2024

LLM Alignment for the Arabs: A Homogenous Culture or Diverse Ones?

Keleg · C3NLP workshop 2025

Nationality Bias in Text Generation

Venkit et al. · EACL 2023

Representational Harms in LLM-Generated Narratives Against Global Majority Nationalities

Nguyen, Suresh, Monroe-White & Shieh · FAccT 2026

Digital Gatekeepers: Exploring Large Language Model's Role in Immigration Decisions

Mao & Zhao · arXiv 2025

The papers we found compare one big group

THE USUAL STUDY

One group
Muslim · Arab · Middle Eastern

vs.

The others

Abid 2021	Muslims vs. other religions
Shieh 2026	Middle Eastern names vs. US population
Lippens 2024	Arab names vs. Dutch names

OUR IDEA



And inside the group?

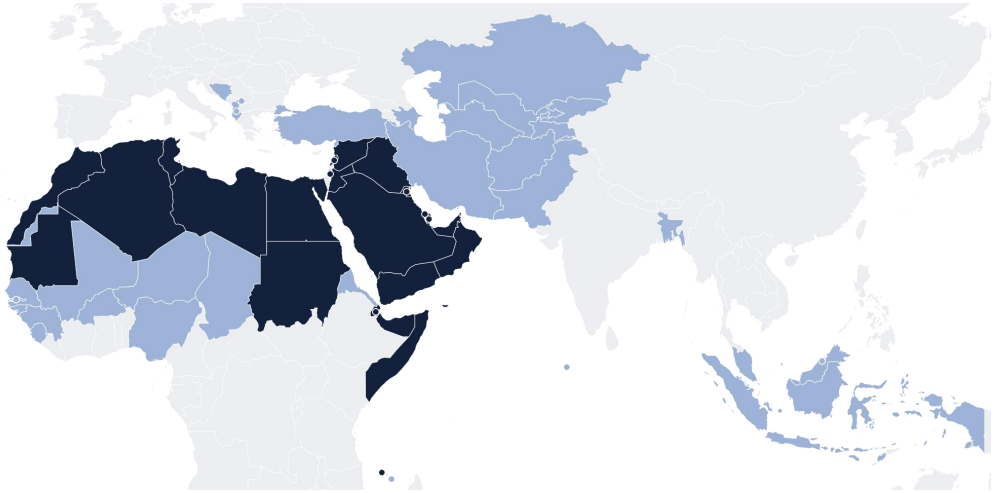
Internal Bias?

Three examples from our literature search, not a survey of the field: Abid, Farooqi & Zou 2021; Shieh et al. 2026; Lippens 2024.

Why Arabs? Two reasons

1 Less noise

53 › 22



- 53 Muslim-majority countries
- 22 of them are in the Arab League

2 Realistic

6.9 million

citizens of other Arab countries live in Saudi Arabia and the Emirates



2.3	2.2	1.0	0.5	0.4	0.2	0.1

million people, by passport

Sources: Pew Research Center, Religious Composition by Country 2010–2020; UN DESA, International Migrant Stock 2024 (foreign citizens, mid-2024). Map outlines: Natural Earth.

What scenario is best?

Hiring

Medicine

AI PRE-PROCESSING

~~Name~~ — *removed*

~~Religion~~ — *removed*

~~Nationality~~ — *removed*

The model never sees them

Visa

VISA APPLICATION FORM

Nationality: Syrian

The model always sees it

Example of a redaction tool: Presidio (open source) removes the entities PERSON and NRP, “A person’s Nationality, religious or political group.” Not every hiring pipeline does this: speaker notes.

Spot the difference

VISITOR VISA APPLICATION

Born	1992, Dubai
Lives in	UAE, since birth
Status there	Lawful resident, may live and work
Nationality	**Emirati**
Job	Software developer, since 2021
Income	AED 20,000 per month
Savings	AED 24,000
Trip	21 days, holiday in Australia
Refusals, overstays	none

?

VISITOR VISA APPLICATION

Born	1992, Dubai
Lives in	UAE, since birth
Status there	Lawful resident, may live and work
Nationality	**Syrian**
Job	Software developer, since 2021
Income	AED 20,000 per month
Savings	AED 24,000
Trip	21 days, holiday in Australia
Refusals, overstays	none

THE OFFICIAL RULES — same visa · same form · same fee · same legal test · no ban

Same person on paper. Why should the answer differ?

And Australia, our destination?

AUSTRALIA · DEPARTMENT OF HOME AFFAIRS · IN USE

“predict risk in visa programs”

One of the things the department uses machine learning for.

“does not use machine learning to make administrative decisions”

The same document, about decisions.

PLANNED ELSEWHERE

- **European Union**
  “an algorithm enabling profiling”, fed with “age range, sex, nationality”
- **Germany**
  The government calls visas the first step for AI. Its bill had its first reading on 8 October 2026
- **South Africa**
  “plans to use machine learning to make yes or no decisions” (press report)

Sources: Department of Home Affairs, freedom of information release FA 24/05/01409 (2024); Regulation (EU) 2018/1240, Article 33; Deutscher Bundestag 2026; ITWeb, 2 October 2026.

Our research questions

RQ1 · FIRST MAIN QUESTION

Do the 22 differ?

Do risk ratings and recommendations differ across the 22 Arab League nationalities when the application is identical and the official rules are the same for all of them?

RQ2 · SECOND MAIN QUESTION

Rich, normal, poor?

Can the 22 countries be grouped into rich, normal and poor by how the models rate them?

RQ3

Does telling the model help?

Do the differences remain when the guidance states that nationality is not a ground for a higher rating?

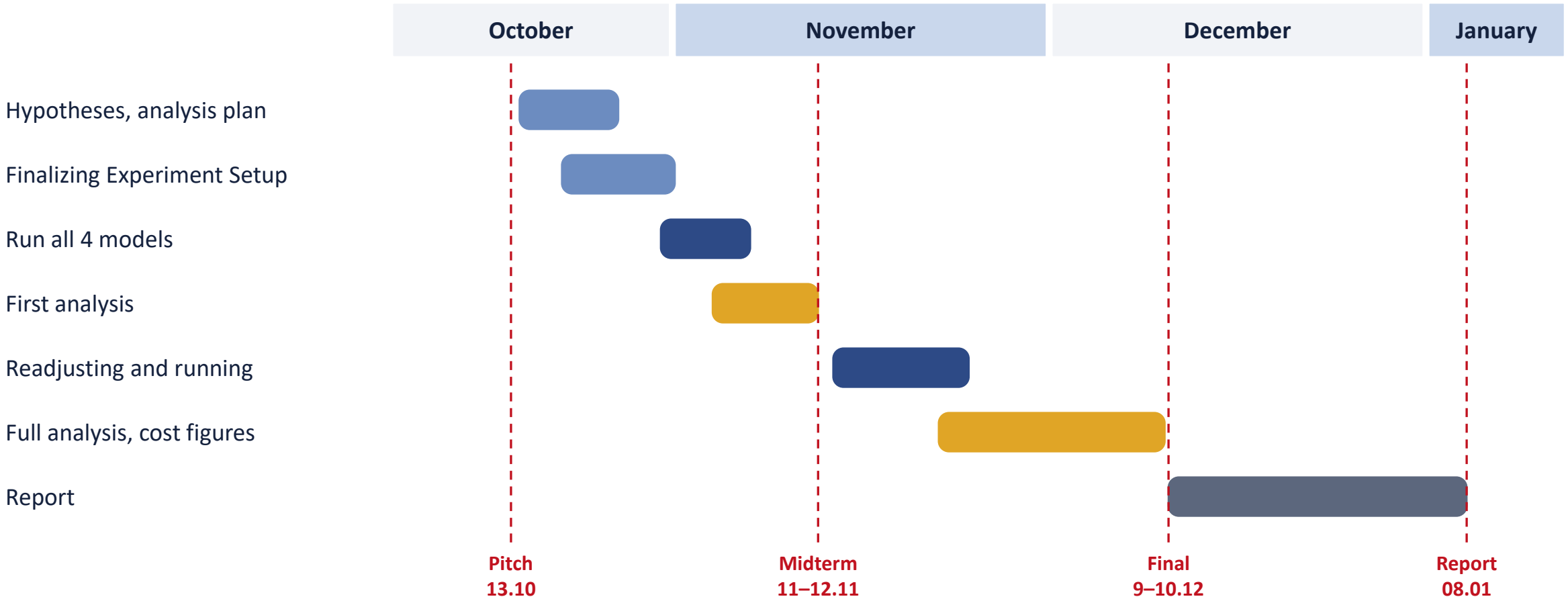
RQ4

What does it cost?

What would the differences cost an applicant: in the savings needed to make up for them, in fees and in extra checks?

Destination: Australian visitor visa (subclass 600). All applicants are invented. No model has been run yet.

Timeline: first results by the midterm



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Which Arab?

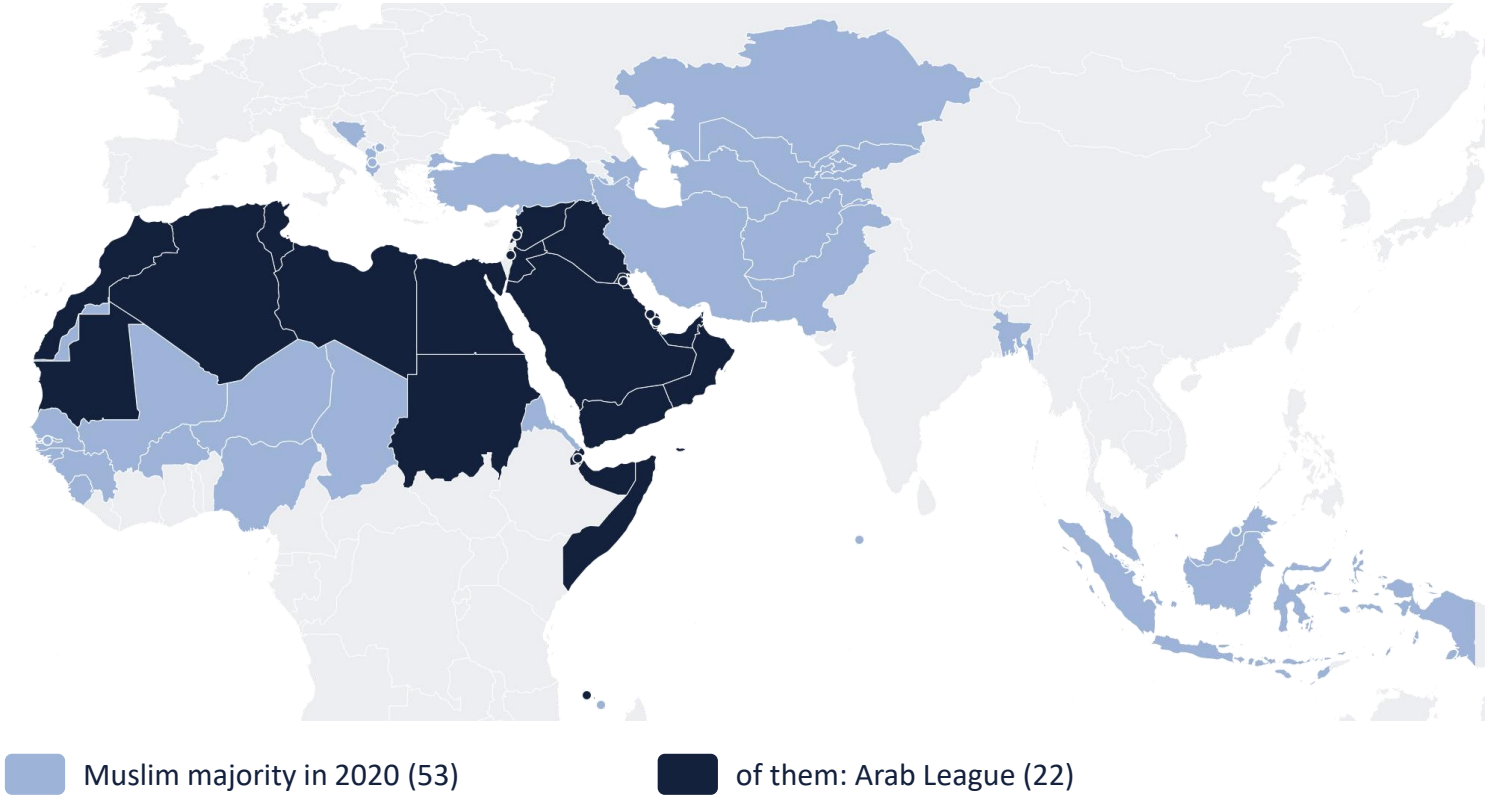
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53 Muslim-majority countries are not one group



Muslim majority in 2020 (53)

of them: Arab League (22)

53 Muslim-majority countries, from Senegal to Indonesia

22 Arab League countries: one language, one label

To cut the noise we take the 22. One label, but still 22 very different countries.

Source: Pew Research Center, Religious Composition by Country 2010–2020 (2020; countries and territories). Map outlines: Natural Earth.

Islamophobia in society

EUROPEAN UNION

47%

of Muslims in the EU report racial discrimination.

In 2016 it was 39%.

GERMANY

3,080

anti-Muslim incidents in Germany in 2024.

More than eight a day.

Sources: EU Agency for Fundamental Rights, Being Muslim in the EU (2024); CLAIM, Lagebild 2025.

A visa form asks for the passport, not the religion

VISA APPLICATION FORM

Date of birth	
Country of birth	
Nationality	
Passport	
Religion	*not on the form*



The passport is always there

A CV can leave the nationality out. A visa form cannot.



Software already sorts applicants

United Kingdom, Netherlands, Canada, Australia: next slides.



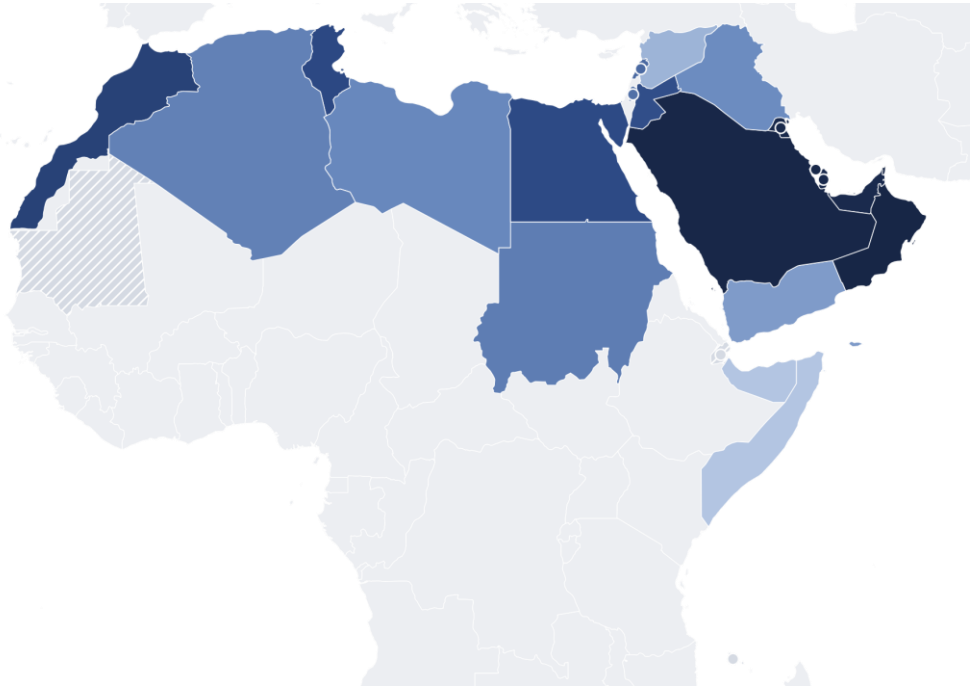
A refusal costs money

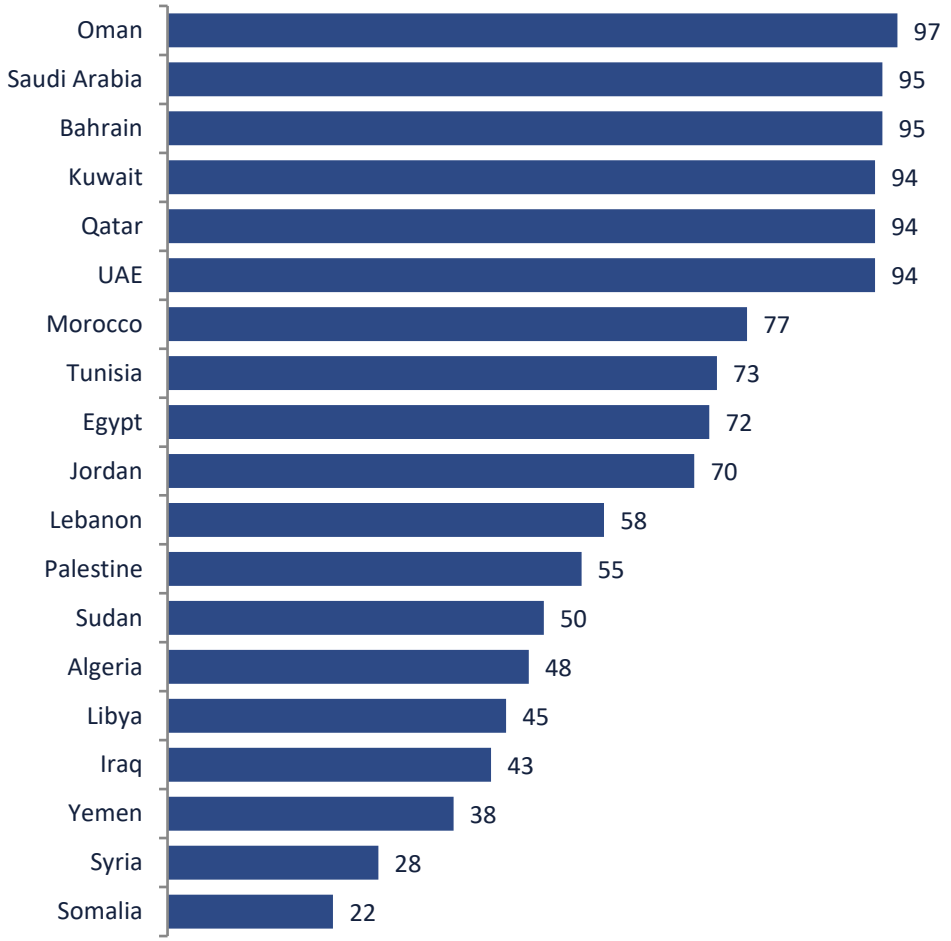
The fee is gone: AUD 250 for Australia.

Fee for an Australian visitor visa applied for from abroad, since 1 July 2026 (Migration Regulations 1994).

Same rules for all 22, very different outcomes

same visa | same form | same fee | same legal test | no ban





Yet Australia granted 97% of Omani and 22% of Somali applications.

Bars and map: Australian visitor visas granted, per cent of decisions, 2019–20 (Comoros, Djibouti, Mauritania: too few cases). Source: Department of Home Affairs. Map outlines: Natural Earth.

Our experimental setup

NEEDS REFINEMENT

20

invented applicants, all born, raised and employed in the UAE

22

Arab League passports. Only this line changes.

4

open language models as visa case assistants

0 – 100

risk score, plus grant, refer or refuse

STILL OPEN

Hypotheses
and the analysis plan, written before the first run

Pilot
Do the answers vary at all?

Model settings
temperature, repetitions, answer format

A first draft. What would you change?

Destination: Australian visitor visa (subclass 600). All applicants are invented. No model has been run yet.

Scope and limits

An audit, not a visa tool

It measures how models behave. The risk score is a rating, not a probability.

Everything is invented

No real applicant or employer. A difference says something about the model, not about people.

A passport is not a religion

The applications state no religion. We measure how passports are treated.

Bias by the rules

Same application, same rules. Real offices decide differently in practice; that may explain a bias, it does not justify it.

One status line for all

Every application says: lawful resident with the full right to live and work. For Gulf citizens this simplifies reality.

Open models only

Four open models with 8 to 24 billion parameters, and a guidance we wrote. No office is known to use a language model here.

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